imperial service. Any man, theoretically, could become a mansabdar, whether or not he had the advantage of ethnic or clan affiliation; whether or not, indeed, he had any military experience. Ranks ranged from 10 to 5000, and only talent – in principle – decided if a man travelled up (or down) these grades. Abul Fazl, for example, came to court with an essay, not a sword; he was appointed to the branding department, as Badauni records, and 'worked so strenuously at the dagh-u-mahalli business, that he managed . . . to raise himself to a mansab of two thousand'.[18]

For anyone of a large mass of people – soldiers, scholars, painters, refugees – looking for a government job, mansabdari would have been a relatively transparent and effective system of employment. For the warlords, on the other hand, whose aspiration was to rule not serve, Akbar's reforms would have appeared like an assault on their pride. And that was partly the point: for mansabdari to work, Akbar would have to effect a fundamental shift in how his nobility conceived of their honour, 'from personal, lineage, or sectarian pride – that of the "free" warrior chief – to a more impersonal, imperial pride – that of the "slave" warrior-administrator'.[19]

This was easier said than done; and Akbar wasn't always very tactful about it. It has even been argued that Abul Fazl's bristling censure of 'the wicked ways of Transoxiana', to accompany Akbar's stern discouragement of his nobility's homosexual love affairs, was part of a 'very public campaign . . . in which [Akbar] juxtaposed his patriarchal and heterosexual model of north Indian male virtue against the corrupt practices of central Asian outsiders'.[20] Indeed, Central Asian chiefs in Hindustan were becoming outsiders to what they might have regarded as their own. By 1580, as Iqtidar Alam Khan has shown, the percentage of Central Asian chiefs in Akbar's court had shrunk to hardly a quarter, having comprised over half at the beginning of his reign.[21]

No wonder, then, that they were on edge. It was in 1580, in fact, that the chiefs of the east rebelled, led by a proud and deeply unhappy clan of Central Asians called the Qaqshals.

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Eight years earlier, when Akbar was marching to Gujarat in 1572, trouble